Rogaine News

July 2002 **NZ 6**

Heights of Winter 2002 – from a course planner

Whatever happened? Out of 96 teams, at least 25 missed the 9.00 pm deadline. They lost heaps of points, and ten were disqualified – they arrived back after the 9.30 course closure. I felt sorry for these guys: they had sweated and grunted for 12 hours, culminating (in some cases) with a 10-km sprint down the road. The last two teams struggled in at 11.15 pm (courtesy of the Red Cross patrol) after most people had gone, including (nearly) the caterers.

The problem was that many teams both overestimated their ability and underestimated the difficulty of the course. A rogaine is not just an endurance race. It involves meticulous planning during the two-hour preparatory period, some subtle route choices, good navigation skills, and the ability to make difficult choices under stress. The key judgement is the one between Greed ("the 90-pointer is just over there, let's pop over and get it") and Caution ("we don't want to risk missing the deadline – particularly as we'll slow right down when darkness sets in"). Out of a total of 59 controls there were 13 on flat land within easy reach of the Start/Finish – including a 50-pointer at the cave with Maori rock drawings (hence the name). Most of these easy controls should have been left to darkness. They provided the opportunity for fine-tuning of timing, i.e., to skip or include a few low pointers so as to finish just before 9.00 pm. It required discipline to pass quickly through these controls during the morning on the way to the distant high-pointers. Six at night and on patrol at the far end of the course I noticed plenty of flashing lights in the hills. What were all those people doing 10 km from the Finish!

Control descriptions were varied (rock pillar, saddle, top of hill, re-entrant, pond) and not too difficult to find. After all, many rogainers are not orienteers and don't have the same subtle navigational skills. One control had mysteriously teleported itself to a nearby hill-top, resulting in a host of complaints afterwards (a big sorry to those affected, and teams who registered a complaint have been credited with the 70 points).

The winners? Keith and Andrea Murray, no surprises there, with a staggering 1850 points out of a possible total of 2580. As well as being overall winners, they also got the prize for the top mixed team. Close behind them were Alistair Cory-Wright and John Fitch with 1830.

Lastly, the acknowledgements. Thank you to the 12 landowners who allowed 260 people to traipse over their land (yes, and had we allowed late entries the figure would have exceeded 300). Thank you, Hurunui Scouts for the excellent catering. Jenny, for not only sharing the planning role with me and being chief 4WDriver, but going far beyond the call of duty whipping up cream cakes and casseroles for the organisers. Thank you, Red Cross for your patrolling and water replenishment work, and even doing the timekeeping. Fortunately, there were no injuries requiring your normal skills. Thank you, Waikari community for the use of your magnificent hall. Thank you, Pete Squires and Bill Kennedy for putting out and collecting the controls, and Brian Smith for handling the entries. And helpers on the day, including Anne and Bayne Hunter, Jill from Wellington, and Rick Bolch. Greg and Michael Smithson have done a great job with computerised results. A special mention to Grant Hunter. As usual, Grant did a lion's share of the work (liaison with farmers, planning, controlling, organising). An event of this size involves an incredible amount of preparation and few have the talent to plan at this level of detail. ***Piers Maclaren***

... and from another organiser

Congratulations all of you. It was a long day on the hill - even too long in some cases. Brian and I agree that one of the hardest tasks this year was saying "no" to late entries. It needn't have been hard for we made it clear there would be no late entries, but the level of disappointment expressed by some

teams was quite humbling. Outdoors, partly thanks to good weather, we handled the numbers OK, but the caterers had to rethink what they could provide for 260.

It was great to see everyone finishing as teams. A downside was the amount of feedback we've had about teams being seen not keeping together when approaching controls. We had no formal protests (but two came close) so we're taking no action this time. But, as teams take rogaining more seriously, they're becoming less tolerant of such behaviour. Competitive teams, especially, should know better. They'll know who they are.

It's an adventure organising rogaines, too – if the pain's not so sharp as competing, the challenge definitely lasts longer. Each time a different setting. Where shall we go? Who owns it? Then getting a dozen landowners to point in the same direction as us (every one we approached said "yes", and one even joined in and what's more finished comfortably in the top third). Then the fun stuff - getting an overall feel for the terrain, planning the route, and paying 3 or 4 visits to each control (using a GPS this year saved one visit). And who knows what fortune the weather will bring on a particular mid-winter Saturday? And then there's even judging the water right. This year we got enough at the right place at the right time – but where were the thirsts? Your commitment to the event and great feedback comments make it worthwhile and enjoyable, thank you. ***Grant***

Lost and found
All we've got left now from Waikari is a hat or two, call 03 351-6369.

Coming up

4 August	"Hope"- full Shoestring Rogaine, Marlborough 3hrs & 6hrs	Casual event for complete novices through to experienced rogainers	Barry Hope 03 578 7168 king.hope@wave.co.nz
24 August	Raggedy EPIC, Ophir, Central Otago, 12hr	Rogaine style route choice with cryptic checkpoints	Bruce McLeod, bmcleod@es.co.nz 03 441 4447
2 November	Queenstown EPIC, 12 hr (back this year!)	as above	as above
7 December	Lower Hawkes Bay, 12 hr	details to follow	Hawkes Bay Orienteering Club (watch NZOF website)
15, 16 March	24 hour, Otago??	listen out for this biggie	watch www.rogaine.org.nz

Many events have early close-off dates, so find out more about these ones pronto.

Grant is looking at organising some 6 or 8 hour events in Canterbury, and trying to attract more tramping types to rogaining – He thought a note in here might make them more likely to happen.

Our best wishes to the 10 or more Kiwi rogainers who are about to depart for the 5th World Rogaining Championships in the Czech Republic, 26-27th July. Don't get confused – keep the needle pointing south, guys.

New Zealand Rogaine Association

Don't forget to visit your rogaine focal point, website www.rogaine.org.nz . There you can register to receive email notification of significant updates. We can't keep everyone fully informed my normal mail so if you aren't hooked-up computerwise, find a rogaine buddy who is (or try your neighbour?). We thank Bill Kennedy and Pete Squires for developing the website.